SYRIA EXPERIENCE IN INNOVATION & INCUBATION

Syria Delegation

Workshop on Services for Innovating Firms
April 28-29, 2011
Marseille

NATIONAL INNOVATION SYSTEM

- Study by giz in 2010
- Priority interventions (implemented with reasonable efforts, have a significant positive impact):
  - National Innovation Strategy
  - Framework conditions for entrepreneurs
  - Institutional innovation supporters (incubators)
  - Clusters

STAKEHOLDERS DISCUSSION

- Bureaucracy is hindering individuals from the extra innovative effort
- **Syrian youth constitute the largest percentage of citizens ➔ companies who create job opportunities are the most important factor**
- **Innovators are mostly young people and/or have no resources**

STAKEHOLDERS DISCUSSION

- The capacity for innovation could make use of the Syrian expatriates.
- While waiting for new born entrepreneurs, activities would be oriented towards the next generation of the family businesses.
- Research-free innovation can be promoted immediately
- Incentives for the innovation mechanism to work on the institutional level then on the national level

EXPERIENCE IN BUSINESS INCUBATION

- Relatively new approach (since 2003)
- Providing general support services: mentoring, training, consultations, networking, promotion and information.
- Mostly start ups in commercial and services sectors.
- Similar challenges

EXPERIENCE IN BUSINESS INCUBATION

- SEBC Business Incubators
  - Started in Damascus 2007, and Aleppo 2009
  - Provide business development services with no special services to innovation
  - Disseminating experience: provide technical assistance for setting up business incubators in Syria

EXPERIENCE IN BUSINESS INCUBATION

- SEBC Business Incubators
  - ~114 startups: Professional, Scientific & Technical Services; Internet Service Provider & Web Portals, Health Care & Social Assistance, Construction, Manufacturing, Information, Accommodation & Food Services, and Real Estate & Rental.
  - ~20 startups related to innovation (eg. manufacturing SWH system with top instantaneous yield, and inventing a tool for converting 2D media to 3D media)

EXPERIENCE IN BUSINESS INCUBATION

- ICT Incubators
  - Syrian Computer Society (SCS) had established three ICT incubators (Damascus 2006, Homs 2010, & Lattakia 2011)
  - Provide a scientific and technical environment of experts, advisers, and infrastructure needed for entrepreneurs to create their investment projects.
  - Contribute in raising the level of ICT industry in Syria

EXPERIENCE IN BUSINESS INCUBATION

- ICT Incubators
  - Training: Concepts of Strategic Management, Projects Management, How to build you business plan, Feasibility Study, Marketing and Market analysis, Legal aspects for establishing companies, Other subjects like intellectual property, and legal issues related to ICT projects specifically.
  - Advisory, and consultancy experts and consultants play the role of mentors

INITIATIVE: YBI CONTEXT

- **Incubators and incubation services enable the transition of innovative ideas into competitive products and services**
- Private involvement in incubation is still not common in Syria
- SSSY is an NGO that aims at the social development of the Syrian youth

INITIATIVE: YBI FEATURES

- Place: within the Industrial Cities
- Partners:
  - The Social Society for Syrian Youth (SSSY)
  - The SMEs Commission (government)
  - The Industrial City in Adra (government)
  - SEBC (semi-governmental)
- Plural approach to funding (corporate sources, government funds, and international donor programs)

INITIATIVE: YBI FEATURES

- Tenants:
  - carefully selected young Syrians (graduates of the VET)
  - entrepreneurs servicing local business communities
- Model: demand-oriented incubation → creating companies based on the needs of the enterprises within the Industrial City

INITIATIVE: YBI SERVICE MIX

- Training and support (knowledge)
- Mentoring by SSSY members & other employers (experience)
- linking incubatees to sources of financial assistance
- Networking

CHALLENGES FOR INCUBATION

- Innovation policy
- Regulatory & Legal infrastructure to support incubation, innovation and entrepreneurship
- Financial /public & private (innovation fund)
- Networking, Partnership & Know–how transfer
- Information centres